The Isle of Theseus

by Senator Bix
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Introduction

"The London Daily Chronicle, September 13th, 1929

ATLANTIS FOUND!?

Ocean adventurer Charles O'Shea has discovered a previously uncharted island the middle of the Atlantic. Hieroglyphics found in ruins on the island indicate an ancient Egyptian settlement that may have given rise to the story of Atlantis. Is it the real deal or bunko? Explorers and researchers are currently on route to the island to find out."

At the end of the article is a picture of three to seven people standing in front of an airplane on a runway, smiling in black and white, joyfully unaware of what might await them.

Who's up for a little mysterious adventure?

Overview

This is a pulp island adventure that's really a dinosaur island adventure that's really really an island cult T-Rex Cthulhu adventure.

This adventure is system agnostic but I've included some stats in 5E style because 5E might be the closest thing to a lingua franca in TTRPGs.

NPCs

- **Victor Uckley:** The pilot. Gruff and weathered. Wears an eye-patch.

- **Charles O'Shea:** Irish explorer. Famous. Leader of the expedition

- **Penny Lang:** American. Reporter. Was a field nurse during the great war.

Other NPC names you can use: Alan Baily, Bernard Mitchell, Edmund Sedgwick, Julian Archer, & Duane Kirkland.

Beginning Events

- **The Flight to the Island:** On route to the island, the players introduce themselves. The pilot challenges one of the players to an arm wrestling contest. This is just to quickly introduce Victor as being friendly, yet tough and competitive. It's also to make sure players have a basic understanding of whatever system you're using.

- **Landing:** As the players come in to land on the island there is an issue. The island has an active volcano (of course it does), and there is

  currently smoke and ash blowing across the landing path. Victor asks for their help deciding if they think he could avoid the smoke landing into the wind or if he should go around and try and land with the wind. Unfortunately, no matter what the players do, the plane will crash, as a trench was dug across the runway. The plane is damaged. Victor is unconscious, and if he's awakened it will be revealed that he is too injured too move. He encourages you to go to the camp to get help. If the players come back for Victor, he will be gone.

Locations

1. **Landing Strip:** A trench was dug across the runway. The plane has basic survival gear and a limited map of the southern half of the island.

2. **Dinosaur Fields Forever:** In the clearing to the side of the road, you see two ankylosauruses. They are fighting each other for dominance, and will ignore the players unless the players go out of their way to draw attention to themselves. If confronted, one ankylosarus will run into the jungle and the other will fight the players before running off.

   Ankylosaurus: AC: 16, HP: 95 ***Attack: Tail*** +9 to hit (reach 10 ft.) for for 3d6 + 3 bludgeoning damage and target is knocked back or prone. ***Attack: Stomp*** +9 to hit (target musts be prone) for 3d10 + 6 bludgeoning damage.

3. **Inland Camp:** The camp setup by the expedition. It is abandoned and was ransacked, but many valuables left behind. The camp has dynamite. Tracks lead into the forest in all directions.

4. **Inland Temple:** An abandoned temple. The outside of this step pyramid is burned and vandalized. There is an entrance at the top of the pyramid, with steps that lead down into the structure. The inside the temple is untouched. Art decorates the walls depicting Thoth, a tall figure with the head of an ibis. Thoth is the god of wisdom, writing, hieroglyphs, and the moon. He was considered the inventor of writing and the creator of the calendar, but here he is depicted sitting at a throne wielding a sword. The room contains four semi-circular niches, each is empty but once contained offerings to the god left by the villagers. At the far end of the room a crude statue is intact and made of stones and mud bricks, and painted black with a gold beak. The two eyes are rubies that would be incredibly valuable. Note: These rubies are in fact **The Eyes of Thoth**.

   Behind the statue is an obscured tunnel that leads down to a small room. There is an empty pedestal in the center of the room, upon which is written "Only Thoth may pull down the sword of the moon." The walls in this room contain two murals, one of Thoth and one with a similar looking pedestal with a what appears to be a jeweled bird sitting on top.

5. **The Theseus:** The Theseus is a large ship the expedition brought to the island. It is currently wrecked off the coast. Supplies can be looted. A detailed map of the island can be found. The ship has dynamite and working radio equipment (you were following the radio beacon to the island). The ship lists with the tide, and exploring it could be difficult.

6. **Volcano:** Players get a little altitude and get a feel for the island. If they don't have a full island map, give the players one to represent their understanding of the geography of the island. Players can see smoke coming from the crash site. If it's dark, players can see fires coming from the Plateau Temple. If you want an encounter here, some pterodactyls can harass the players.

   Pterodactyl: AC: 12, HP: 7 ***Attack: Talons or Beak*** +4 to hit for 1d4 + 2 slashing damage.

7. **Cinder Temple:** The Cinder Temple is similar in layout to the Inland Temple. However, it is clear from bedding and an area set aside for cooking that this area is being used as shelter, although it is currently unoccupied. Evidence of people and claw marks abound. Any Thoth images have been defiled, but players can make out a mural showing the Thoth holding two swords up to the sky, raining destruction upon a lizard headed god and his followers. Written in Egyptian is, "Only Thoth may pull down the swords of the moon."

8. **The River:** The easiest way up the plateau is along this river path. You find two leaf-people patrolling the river. One of them is riding a triceratops. If the players confront the patrol, the one with the triceratops will attempt to fight the players while the other will attempt to flee back to the Plateau Temple to raise an alarm. However, even if he makes it to the Plateau Temple, an alarm will not be raised because of events unfolding in the temple.

   Triceratops & Rider: (If the rider is knocked off or incapacitated, the Triceratops will try to flee the combat.) AC: 13, HP: 95 ***Attack: Gore*** +9 to hit for 4d8 + 6 piercing damage. ***Attack: Stomp*** +9 to hit for 3d10 + 6 bludgeoning damage. ***Bonus Attack: Rider's Spear*** +3 to hit for 1d6 + 1 piercing damage.

   Leaf-People Warrior: AC: 12, HP: 11 ***Attack: Spear*** +3 to hit (range 20/60 ft. if thrown) for 1d6 + 1 piercing damage.

9. **Plateau Temple:** This temple is larger than the others. There is a single entrance at the top, like the others, but once inside the path forks. One path leads to an arena, while the other leads to a series of connected rooms overlooking the arena, the last of which are the quarters of the Leaf-People Commander. If the Idol is not in the arena, then it is here.

   The arena has cages at the side nearest the entrance. At the far side there is a T-Rex sized tunnel that leads to a cave that exits somewhere in the forest.

   Leaf-People Commander: AC: 16, HP: 38 ***Multiattack:*** The Commander makes three melee attacks or two ranged attacks. ***Attack: Axe*** *+7 to hit (range 20/60 ft. if thrown) for 2d6 + 4 piercing damage.* **Attack: Shield Bash** +7 to hit for 2d4 + 4 bludgeoning damage and target is knocked back.

10. **The Merlin:** The boat that brought Penny Lang is undamaged and anchored just off the island. It is not being guarded. The players have already been through enough.

Notes

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Info

The Idol of Thoth: An ornate statue of a falcon, but the gems it once had for eyes are missing. On the Idol written in Egyptian is, “The sword of Thoth hangs overhead, a display of his glowing might. A world soaked in blood cannot be redeemed and so must end.”

Leaf-People (The Cult of Alkelith): The followers of Alketih cover their bodies in volcanic ash and wear a mask made from leaves found on the island. On closer inspection, they can be found to have a variety of reptilian features, such as green skin, sharpened teeth. Some members of the cult are European, as the people from the Inland Camp have been assimilated.

Early Game Encounters

1. **Leaf-people. Fear venom.** The leaf-people will hide in the forest, harassing players.

   Leaf-Perople Sniper: AC: 12, HP: 11 ***Attack: Blowgun*** +1 to hit (range 25/100 ft.) for 1 piercing damage and the target is confronted by their greatest fear.

2. **Venom Dinosaurs:** A small group of dilophosaurus on the hunt.

   Venom Dinosaurs: AC: 13, HP: 9 ***Attack: Bite.*** +4 to hit for 1d4 + 1 piercing damage. ***Attack: Acid Spray.*** +3 to hit (range 30/60 ft.) for 2d6 acid damage.

Mid-Game Encounters

3. **Leaf-people and Raptors:** A few leaf-people paroling with some raptors. The people of the island seem to be able to work with the dinosaurs.

   Leaf-Perople Warrior: AC: 12, HP: 11 ***Attack: Spear*** +3 to hit (range 20/60 ft. if thrown) for 1d6 + 1 piercing damage.

   Raptors: AC: 14, HP: 11 ***Attack: Bite*** +4 to hit for 2d4 + 2 piercing damage. ***Attack: Claw*** +4 to hit for 2d6 slicing damage.

4. **Victor Uckley:** He has been trying to catch up with the group. He saw people from the Inland Camp being taken to the Plateau Temple and wants us to go rescue them. He seems out of it. He might have a concussion.

5. **Penny Lang:** She was sent to report on the island and arrived with two historians a on a sailboat (The Merlin) that had come from Morocco. She arrived two weeks before the players arrived and was there when the Inland Camp was attacked. Penny escaped into the jungle and has been avoiding detection. She went back to look for the boat that brought her, but it is not where it was anchored. Since the plane crash she has been trying to find the players. Penny was a field nurse during The Great War, so she’s seen some things.

Endgame Encounters

6. **Tyrannosaurus Rex**

   T-Rex: AC: 13, HP 136 ***Multiattack:*** The tyrannosaurus makes two attacks: one with its bite and one with its tail. It can’t make both attacks against the same target. ***Attack: Bite*** +10 to hit (reach 10 ft.) for 4d12 + 7 piercing damage. ***Attack: Tail*** +10 to hit (reach 10 ft.) for 3d8 + 7 bludgeoning damage.

Cutscene: Charles O’Shea and the Cult of Alkelith

(This scene takes place inside the Plateau Temple arena, but players reluctant to go to the Plateau Temple could stumble upon it out in the forest. It sets up the final act of the adventure.)

O’Shea is in trouble for bringing the Idol of Thoth. It is a forbidden object from a forbidden temple. O’Shea is being confronted by the Leaf-People Commander and many Warriors. The Leaf-People strikes O’Shea, almost severing Irishman’s arm.

O’Shea pleas: “Please. I didn’t know. Don’t kill me. I can help. We still have a radio on the ship. I can call more people. I could bring them here. They could bring you anywhere. But they will only come if I ask them. Please don’t kill me.”

The Commander examines the Idol and laughs. At the far end of the arena are the thunderous steps of some creature. “It’s not me you need to beg for your life.” The commander looks over as a T-Rex enters the arena from a cave opening at the far end of the arena. This is the earthly manifestation of the god Alkelith. The T-Rex walks over to O’Shea, who is holding his arm, paralyzed with fear. The T-Rex opens its enormous jaws, revealing gray-blue tentacles. The T-Rex leans over, but stops short of biting O’Shea. The tentacles reach out and O’Shea disappears among them. When O’Shea emerges, his injured arm has replaced with a green, lizard arm ending in claws."

The Commander looks at the Idol of Thoth then throws it aside. “Alkelith has forgiven you, but you only live because the Idol is powerless without it’s eyes. But since you do live, then you will be more than useful to us. You will become us, as we become him.” O’Shea is taken out of the arena, the T-Rex leaves the same way it came in, and people begin to dissipate.

(*There a lot of things players could do at this point. Maybe they want to get the Idol. Maybe they want to flee. Maybe they want to jump into combat. I say go with the flow. My players had two leaf-people masks and rolled in pretending unmasked players were captives to try and get The Idol. They did the Death Star wookiee thing, which never even occurred to me when I was making the adventure. TTRPGs are just the best.*)

Cutscene: Uckley's Betrayal

At some point Uckley will betray the players. Maybe he announced your presence while you're trying to hide in the Plateau Temple. Mabe he pretends to be taken hostage. He doesn't want the players dead; he wants you brought into the fold of the Cult of Alkelith. When his betrayal is revealed, Uckly will remove his eye-patch, revealing a strange reptilian eye.

Cutscene: The Eyes of Thoth are placed in The Idol of Thoth

If the Eyes of Thoth are placed in the Idol of Thoth, the players can feel it almost vibrate with a strange energy. At some point, the Idol will summon Thoth. (On the playtest for this adventure the players brought the Idol back to the pedestal at the Inland Temple, so that was a great time for him to show up. When Thoth does appear is completely at the GM's discretion.)

When Thoth appears he will tell the players that he's got this under control, and that he will pull the moon down to stop the threat of Alkelith. If the players object the destruction of the world, Thoth will ask them how they plan on stopping Alkelith. He's open to any plans the players might have. Thoth likes people.

- Maybe the players convince Thoth to confront Alkelith himself.
- Maybe the players can convince Thoth to only destroy the island.
- Maybe the players try to blow up the Alkelith T-Rex or the Plateau Temple.
- Maybe if he can't be convinced to save the world, the players pull the gems from the Idol's eyes, causing Thoth to disappear.

Conclusions

- Maybe the players sabotage the radio on The Thesius, foiling Alkelith's plans to escape.
- Maybe the players manage to find and escape on the Merlin.
- Maybe Thoth is thankful to the players, telling them the location of the Marlin and giving them a chance to escape before he pulls the island into the sea.
- Maybe Thoth and Alkelith fight as the island is destroyed around them.
- Before being captured by the cult, O'Shea radioed for help. A seaplane arrives just as it is needed in what I'm calling deus ex seaplane.

There are a lot of ways the adventure could end, but I feel like they could all provide a good resolution to a story. Having a lot of options available lets the players always feel like they made the right choice, even if it was only a right choice.

And that's it.

Thanks for reading. I hope this adventure sounded like fun.

- Bix

If you're looking for a system to run this adventure with . . .

- **Mini Six** by Ray Nolan (http://www.antipaladingames.com/) a streamlined system inspired by OpenD6. It's esay to pick up and setting neutral, so it's my go-to for one shots.
- **Into the Odd: Pocket Edition** by Silver Nighingale (https://silvernightingale.itch.io/into-the-odd-pocket-edition), a one page version of Chris McDowell's Mark of the Odd SRD.

Acknowledgments

- This uses the map and some location descriptions from Escape from Dead Bird Isle by Glynn Seal from the 2019 One Page Dungeon Contest. (http://www.monkeyblooddesign.co.uk) Licensed CC-BY-SA.
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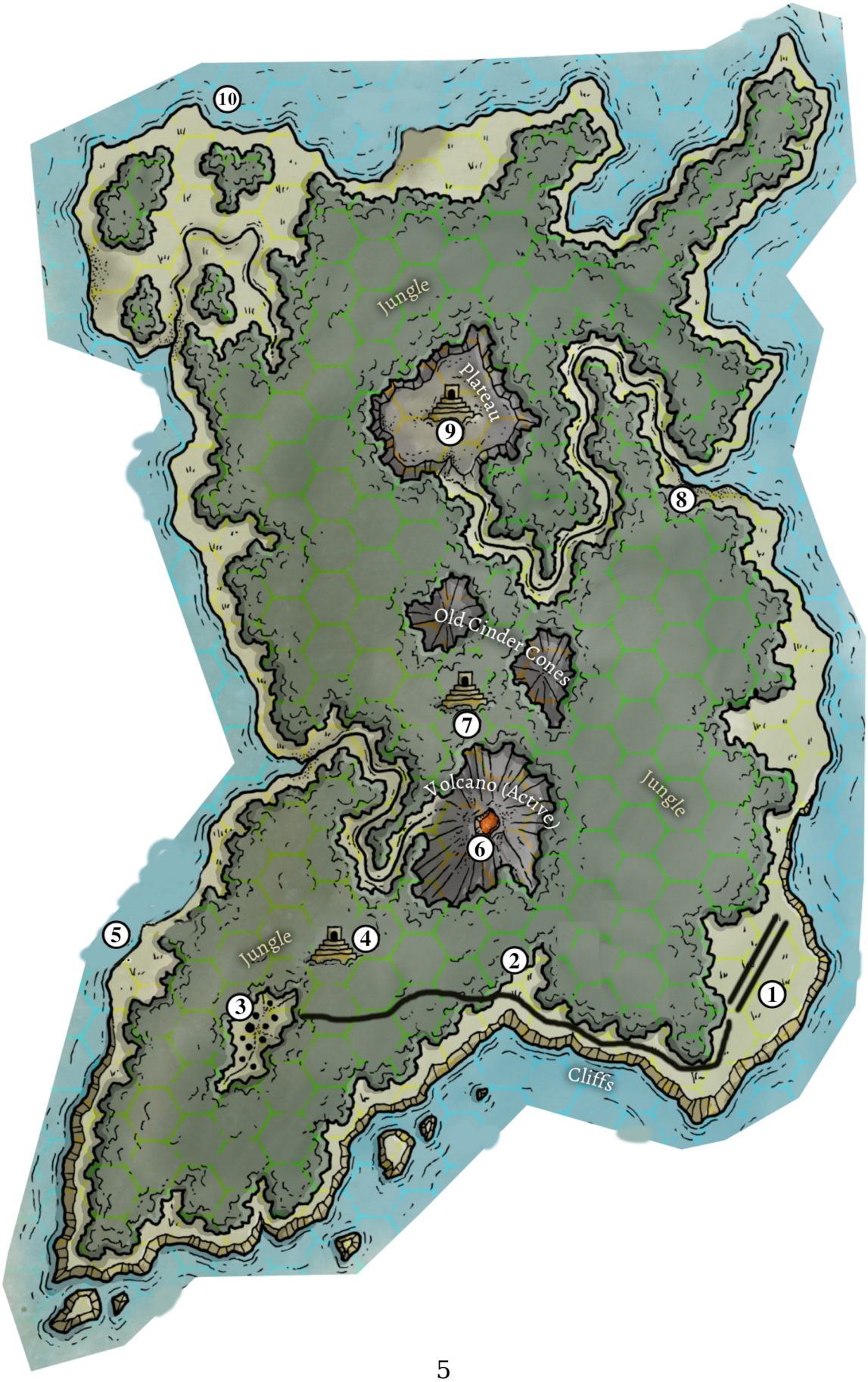
The Isle of Theseus